



WEST TERRACE STREET in Altadena. “We were 100% alone,” one resident of the west side said. “There was no system to alert people.”

Rebuild homes in fire-prone areas?

Residents on one tight-knit Altadena street ravaged by flames face question.

By Rebecca Ellis

They were drawn to the Altadena foothills for the hummingbirds and the bats and the peacocks. It was the view of the canyon, downtown skyscrapers and Santa Catalina Island, somehow all in one frame.

Everyone on Leilani Way knew the risks of living in the San Gabriel Mountains’ fire-prone foothills. The benefits just outweighed them.

“That ability of being near the wildlands wasn’t just a scary threat,” said Erik Ghenoiu, who treasured daily dog walks on the trails. “It was part of what we all loved about it.”

But residents say the last week has served as a brutal reminder of the stakes as they watched flames leap out of the foothills and leave their oak-tree dotted refuge looking like a moonscape. Ghenoiu’s home is gone. So are most of his neighbors’.

As thousands of reeling homeowners weigh rebuilding, residents of the tight-

knit street are forced to confront an even more fraught question — not just should they rebuild, but should they do it in an area likely to burn again.

“We’re obviously torn. ... Part of you wants to do it right away. And part of you is hesitant to even think about rebuilding in the same place,” Ghenoiu said. “Should we build in these sites at all?”

For years, L.A. County officials have been trying to deter people from doing just that. One month before fire tore through Altadena, the planning agency notched a victory with the passage of a zoning update years in the making. It barred more homes in unincorporated swaths of the western San Gabriel Valley, which the state has designated a “Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone.”

That includes the foothills of Altadena, where at least two people have died in the Eaton fire, according to addresses provided by the coroner.

Amy Bodek, who leads the county’s planning department, said the plan won’t have an effect on homeowners who are simply looking to rebuild their

[See **Rebuild**, A11]



A KERN COUNTY fire captain directs his crews battling the Eaton fire Jan. 8 in Altadena. Free trauma-informed counseling is available for first responders.

Fire crews also battle trauma

By Kevin Baxter

Mike McGrew estimates his family has more than 320 years of cumulative experience in police and firefighting work.

His dad was chief of the Santa Barbara Fire Department. His grandfather was with the Los Angeles Fire Department. He was a police officer for 31 years.

“I’ve got a long line over three generations,” the re-

tired homicide and major crimes detective said.

But those centuries of public service have left deep scars, some of which may never heal. So McGrew knows from experience that many of the thousands of first responders working the spate of wildfires in Southern California over the last two weeks will eventually head home weighed down by memories of the death and destruction they have seen.

“It hits you personally,”

he said.

“They’re good in the fight. They’re doing what they have to do, the first responders. But then comes the fight after the fight. How do you deal with those things?”

To help in that fight, McGrew co-founded 911 At Ease International, a Santa Barbara-based charity that provides free trauma-informed counseling for police and firefighters. The group is one

[See **Trauma**, A14]

ALERT CAME HOURS INTO BLAZE

Western Altadena, where 17 died, got evacuation order later than other areas.

By Terry Castleman and Ian James

All of the 17 deaths confirmed so far in the Eaton fire occurred in areas of western Altadena that received emergency evacuation orders many hours after the fire started.

The fire roared out of Eaton Canyon around 6:30 p.m. Jan. 7, pushed west by intense Santa Ana winds. Many neighborhoods in eastern Altadena and surrounding areas got evacuation warnings and orders that Tuesday night.

But records reviewed by The Times show that Altadena neighborhoods west of North Lake Avenue did not get electronic evacuation orders until 3:25 a.m. and never received evacuation warnings. By then, burning embers were raining down on neighborhoods on the west side of Altadena and igniting homes.

The first radio report of fire west of Lake came at 10:51 p.m. on the 500 block of East Calaveras Street. Subsequent calls at 11:42 p.m. and 11:55 p.m. relayed reports of additional fires on the block.

By 2 a.m., witnesses said, Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department patrols were driving down streets west of Lake and using loudspeakers to urge people to evacuate.

The fire ended up decimating western Altadena, burning large swaths of the community from New York Drive north to the foothills of the San Gabriel Mountains. In total, more than 7,000 structures were burned. While the search for victims continues, L.A. coroners’ office records indicate all the deaths occurred west of Lake.

L.A. County emergency officials declined to discuss details of the evacuation process, which they described as a unified command involving the Sheriff’s Department, county Fire Department and other agencies.

[See **Alerts**, A8]

Trump pardons Jan. 6 riot offenders

By Brittney Mejia and Kevin Rector

Federal prosecutors described David Dempsey as “one of the most violent rioters” during the Jan. 6, 2021, insurrection at the U.S. Capitol.

The Van Nuys man used flagpoles, metal crutches and broken pieces of furniture as he stormed the building, injuring police officers and other insurrectionists, according to court documents. He “viciously assaulted and injured police officers” for more than an hour “during one of the most violent stretches of time, at the scene of the most violent confrontations,” prosecutors wrote.

In August, he was sentenced to 20 years in prison after pleading guilty to assaulting a law enforcement officer with a dangerous

[See **Pardons**, A7]

Immigrant rights advocates gear up for legal fights



ANTI-TRUMP demonstrators rally in Chicago on Monday. Some of the new president’s executive orders are based on legally dubious claims, opponents said.

Groups challenging orders face a savvier Trump administration

By Andrea Castillo

WASHINGTON — A day after President Trump issued a dozen executive orders cracking down on illegal immigration, advocates and a coalition of states led by California are preparing for court battles against an administration that appears to have learned from previous legal missteps made during Trump’s first term.

Among the many sweeping changes in Trump’s orders were the declaration of a national emergency at the southern border, the revocation of birthright citizenship and the designation of drug cartels as foreign terrorist organizations.

Immigrants and those

who hoped to immigrate to the U.S. are reeling from the news. Thousands of migrants are indefinitely stranded in Mexico after Trump ended use of a phone app and canceled long-standing appointments by asylum seekers for legal entry. Afghan refugees who had been cleared for travel to the United States are now in limbo after Trump paused refugee resettlement. Undocumented immigrants in Chicago and other cities across the country stayed home out of fear of planned immigration raids.

Legal experts said subtle modifications to some of the orders reflected attempts by the Trump administration to beat back legal challenges

[See **Trump**, A7]

A bit of rain, relief in forecast

A small amount is expected in Southland, breaking a long dry spell. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Will L.A.-area fires hit tourism?

Officials look for signs of blazes’ effect on a popular destination for travelers. **BUSINESS, A10**

How Dodgers landed Sasaki

Over a sushi dinner, players made pitch to Japanese player, led by Ohtani. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather
Mostly sunny, warm.
L.A. Basin: 78/51. **B6**

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